Advice on essay writing

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1. Basic principles and considerations

- Before putting pen to paper or finger to keyboard, get your brain into gear.
- All writing requires preparation, forward planning, and constant evaluation and revision of your plans.

  - Time spent planning will pay dividends later, when the writing process goes more smoothly.

- A good principle to operate on is **emulation**, a fancy word for copying. Look at samples of writing on the subject published in good international journals — for instance, if you are writing on sociolinguistics, have a look at articles in journals of sociolinguistics (e.g. *Language in Society*, and *Journal of Sociolinguistics*).

  - The samples show you what an end-product could look like, but don't give much of an idea of how to go about producing it. It is one of the foci of this document to explain some of the doing processes.
  - I mention just three sample articles that reveal intelligent design and good argumentation (all are available online from electronic journals at the State Library):

Alibali, Matha W., Kita, Sotaro & Young, Amanda J. 2000. Gesture and the process of speech production: we think therefore we gesture. *Language and Cognitive Processes* 15. 593-613. (Psycholinguistics, experimental reportage.)

Davidse, Kristin. 1999. The semantics of cardinal versus enumerative existential constructions. *Cognitive Linguistics* 10. 203-250. (Grammar, grammatical argumentation.)

Duranti, Alessandro. 1990. Politics and grammar: agency in Samoan political discourse. *American Ethnologist* 40. 646-666. (Sociolinguistics; conversation analysis; politics and grammar.)

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1.1 Be aware

- This document contains a considerable number of points of detail about planning, organising and presenting your data and ideas.
- Don't get too bogged down with details: the process of writing takes years to hone to a skill. **Don't expect to learn it all at once.**
- It may be helpful to read this document and look at a sample article at the same time.
- This document is not meant as a recipe book — there is no recipe for good writing.
- You learn most by **doing**. The following hints are meant to help you in the process of doing, and are not to be followed slavishly as a recipe for producing a good essay.

  - Ideally, as you progress through your years studying linguistics your essays should come closer and closer to the shape described here.
  - Your lecturer will have different expectations according to your stage in the courses.

☞ So read this document, attempt to follow the main principles, but don't let the details hinder you. Don't expect to be perfect from the beginning; try to improve over time, with practice.

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2. Preliminary considerations

- Decide on a topic to write on:
  - usually you should choose a topic that interests you;
  - make sure you choose something manageable in the time available;
  - it is advisable to consult with your lecturer to ensure that you are not attempting too ambitious (or too trivial) a project.
- Search the library and internet for relevant literature and data. The best places to begin are:
  - textbooks for the course, and references they cite;
  - your course outline and references cited in it;
  - dictionaries, encyclopaedias and handbooks of linguistics and sub-disciplines of linguistics.
- Take notes while reading — be careful to be **accurate**, and **understand** what the writer is saying.
  - Always note page numbers for the important and relevant information that you might want to use. If you don't do this, you may have to double up on work again if you want to use the information in your essay.
  - Note down good quotations, remembering to follow the **exact wording** of the source, including spelling. This includes spelling mistakes — these should be indicated by *sic* to show that they are the author's error, not yours. E.g. "Take knotes (sic) while reading".
  - Keep a careful record of works consulted, including all of the relevant bibliographical details (see below).
- **Organise your thoughts!**
  - Identify the main ideas, themes, etc. from your readings.
  - Attempt to put them together coherently into a story.
  - Put together a tentative outline of the structure of the essay (see §4.3).

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3. Planning

- Plan each stage of writing your essay — make sure that you choose something doable in the time available. It is a good idea to talk to your lecturer about your ideas.

- Put together a **plan** of how you will spend your time so that you don't run out of it.

  - You may find the plan is unworkable; if so, don't stick to it rigidly. Make changes as necessary to make it realistic, and be able to complete it in the time available.
  - Always make sure you leave sufficient time for actual writing-up of the essay — this is always a very time-consuming process, so don't underestimate it. Even the most experienced writers often take longer to write than they expect.

3.1 Time tabling

- It is often a good idea to work **backwards** from the submission date to the beginning (which ought to be right **now**):

  - **dd/mm/yy**: deadline; hand in paper on time!
  - **dd-1**: print out the final version — never leave this until the last day, or you'll find that there's no paper, the printer is broken, you wake up late, it snowed during the night, etc. etc. Add in extras such as graphics, handwritten notes, diacritics, or whatever isn't in the computer files
  - **dd-3**: print out the next to last version, and proof read it very carefully. Have you got the references complete and correct?
  - **dd-4**: make sure you have your conclusion and final version of the introduction complete
  - **asap**: work out a feasible time table for completing the sections of the body of the text; leave the introduction and conclusion til last — these are the hardest bits to write unless you are very experienced
  - **asap**: work out a general plan for the essay (sections, and their main content)
  - **by about week 7 or 8 of the course** (if not before): hand an abstract or outline of what you propose to do — about a paragraph. The lecturer will comment on it.
  - **week 6 of course or before**: begin your serious reading schedule. You should begin your reading before you plan too much writing. However, don't leave the planning and writing until after you've done all the reading — usually there will be too much material.
  - **by no later than week 6 of course** — decide on a topic to write on, and let your lecturer know what it is. Discuss your selection with your lecturer.
  - **by yesterday**: look through the course description and textbook for topics you find interesting — skim the entire textbook. Read more carefully topics that seem interesting. Don't get bogged down at this stage.

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4. Structure of essay

*4.1. Essays must be **about something***

- Identify a theme or thesis for the paper — it has to be **about** something, not just a collection of random thoughts cobbled together.

  - The thesis will be a proposition or hypothesis that relates to this thing that the essay is about — e.g. the thesis of an article of mine is that a set of expressions satisfying certain conditions in Nyulnyulan languages form a distinct construction type.
  - Try to write down the thesis in a single sentence, as I have just done.
  - Have you ever read an article or book that is not (or appears not to be) about anything? Did you enjoy it? Unlikely!

- Organise your essay around the **thesis** — everything in the essay should relate to the thesis, and develop it. Don't go off on too many tangents, with badly integrated information.

  - The essay should develop a case for the thesis, argue for it; think carefully of how you can make the argument most convincing
  - Note that this applies also if your piece is primarily a critique — the critique needs a thesis too. E.g. I might write a paper critiquing the claim that there is nothing peculiar about the cognitive processing employed in language or speech. My thesis might be that there is something unique about it; it might alternatively be that the evidence is insufficient to make a coherent case for or against.

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4.2 Basic structure

- Basic structure of essays — it is always a good idea to divide the essay into numbered sections with headings: this helps the reader find their way around it. You should generally have:

  - INTRODUCTION — where you present background to the paper, identifying your thesis, and situating it within the wider context of relevant psycholinguistic thought; also indicate the general plan of development of the essay. The introduction is normally numbered 1.
  - BODY of text — this presents the details that elaborate and justify your thesis; do not include anything that is not relevant to the thesis (or if something is not obviously relevant, explain how it is relevant). The body should be divided into numbered sections dealing with particular subthemes; you can also make hierarchies within the numbering, with sections 2.1, 2.2, etc., as in this document.

    - Avoid too many levels — consider three the maximum (as in e.g. §2.1.3).

- You might want to include a section giving a literature review (normally §2), though this is not essential — an alternative is to integrate literature where relevant in your text. This usually makes for a more readable piece, though can be more difficult to write.

- CONCLUSION — this winds up the paper by briefly summarising it: mentions the main thesis and point of the paper, and outlines the main evidence adduced in the paper. Comment on any especially significant or recurrent difficulties or problems encountered on the way, and try to link your thesis to the wider world! (Note that a conclusion is not just a summary.) The conclusion should be numbered sequentially after the last numbered section of the body of the essay.
- REFERENCES — list of works referred to in the text; do not include works that you don't refer to. (See below.) The reference section is not normally numbered.
- APPENDIX — if relevant, you might want to include some of the data collected (if you collected data) in one or more appendixes, which should be numbered (Appendix 1, Appendix 2, …) if more than one. These should normally follow the references. Remember that an appendix is not necessarily read, and nothing crucial to your argument should be included. If you want to use examples to illustrate a point in your argument, they should normally be given at the relevant point of the text — don't say "see Appendix 1".

- Sometimes an ABSTRACT is required. An abstract is more than a summary. The idea is to give a concise presentation of the entire paper in a paragraph, in a way that will hopefully intrigue the reader sufficiently to make them want to read the whole thing. Thus it needs to give an idea of the motivation of the study, a statement of the problem to be addressed, the approach, the results, and the conclusions. Abstract writing is not easy, and takes a good deal of practice.

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4.3. Outlines

- Sample outline for essay *The interaction between grammatical mood and pragmatics, implications to the organisation of a semiotically informed grammar*

1. Introduction:
   what I'm going to do; main problem and idea to develop; background information (what is grammatical mood? what is pragmatics? what are the problems in relating them?); organisation of the paper

2. Mood in Semiotic Grammar:
   critical outline of how SG incorporates mood into the grammar

3. Pragmatic account of illocutionary acts:
   critical account of pragmatic approaches to illocutionary acts and force — where does grammar fit in these accounts?

4. SG meets Pragmatics:
   how does SG suggest grammar and pragmatics interact? What specific proposals does the theory make, and how viable are they? Any difficulties?

5. Conclusions:
   summary of argument; problems; implications for future development of SG and pragmatics

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4.4. Quotes

- Quotes — one often wants to quote another writer (**not** plagiarise them). Bear the following in mind:

  - If the quote is from a word to about 3 lines in length, enclose it in quotation marks within the flow of your text — e.g. *it follows that "morphemes are constructions" (Goldberg 1995:23)*, or *thus, according to Goldberg (1995:23), "morphemes are constructions"*
  - If it is much longer than that, indent it from the left edge of the page, as follows (you can also indent from the right hand margin if you like, but this is not essential):

    Both views — the one appealing to Logic for help and the other indicating an autonomous rule for Grammar — are equally in disagreement with the facts and to be rejected. It is nothing short of absurd to assume, with the rigid grammarian, that grammar has grown up as a sort of wild weed of human faculties for no purpose whatever except its own existence. The spontaneous generation of meaningless monstrosities in the brain of Man will not be easily admitted by psychology — unless of course the brain is that of a rigid scientific specialist. (Malinowski 1923:327)

  - In some books and journals you will find quotes set in smaller font. This is not advised for essays. Keep to the standard 12 point font.

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4.5. Tables and figures

- It is often helpful to use tables and figures (including photographs) to provide a clear overview of a set of data and/or to help explain some point; but always provide sufficient explanation in your text so that the reader knows what is represented in the table or figure, and how to interpret it.

  - Think about the best way of presenting the data in a table or figure: would a graph give a good representation, and if so, what type of graph (e.g. pie graph, bar graph, or whatever).

- It is best to number tables and figures sequentially through the paper, and give them a caption e.g. Table 1: *Cardinal adverbs*; Figure 5: *Family tree for the Worrorran languages*. Then refer to them by number (e.g. see Table 1, etc.) in your text.
- Below is an example illustrating how to lay out a table:

	Actor NP	*-na*	%	*-ma*	%	*-nma*	%	unmarked	%*
intransitive & quasitransitive	nominal	6	3	1	0.4	1	0.4	221	97
	pronominal	0	0	0		0	0	30	100
	ellipsed							477	68
	total	6	1	1	0.1	1	0.1	698	99
middle1 & middle2	nominal	14	52	6	22	5	19	2	7
	pronominal	1	33	2	66	0	0	0	0
	ellipsed							71	70
	total	15	15	8	8	5	5	73	72
transitive & ditransitive	nominal	52	50	23	21	20	19	9	9
	pronominal	34	87	1	3	0	0	4	10
	ellipsed							739	84
	total	86	10	24	3	20	2	752	85

Table 2: *Frequency of ergative marking and non-marking of Actor NPs in Warrwa narratives*

Notes

* The percentages given in this column are the percentages of unmarked NPs to all NPs, and of ellipsed NPs to all instances of the Actor role.

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4.6. Linguistic examples

- There are standard ways (with some slight variations) of presenting examples in linguistics, that you should follow. The main principles are:

  - Give examples in foreign languages in three lines: a source line (the example in the language), an interlinear gloss line (glossing each segmented word or morpheme from the source line), and a free translation into the language of the article.
  - Align words in the source and interlinear lines, using tabs (not spaces), and make sure that each word and morpheme that is shown in the source line has an interlinear gloss.
  - Use abbreviations for the glosses of grammatical morphemes (see below).
  - Number examples sequentially throughout the paper, and refer to examples in the text by number (e.g. "see example (32)").

- Examples of the appropriate way of presenting linguistic examples:

(1) *mee* *binya:* *yarn.gu:* *gumbia:,* *garnmarn.gu:,* *ngarrambu*
veg.food this kapok potato long:yam root:food:type
an-birr-mira-ngi Wunambal
HUM.O-3PL.S-grab-PA
'They got these foods: kapok roots/shoots, potatoes, long yam, and *ngarrambu*.'

(2) *wamb-in* *barn* *i-na-w* *burruk* *jilaman-nyirr* Nyulnyul
man-ERG shoot 3MIN.NOM-CM-give kangaroo rifle-COM
'The man shot the kangaroo with a rifle.'

- For more detailed description, see Leipzig Glossing Rules.

  - This document also provides a list of standard abbreviations, which it is recommended you follow.
  - In case you use abbreviations not on their list, you should note them in a footnote, usually immediately before the first example cited in the article.

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4.7. Other things to bear in mind

- What can you assume? This is not an easy question to answer, and it is impossible to give precise rules. But you want to convey to the marker (examiner) that you understand the subject matter, and can reason about it. Therefore you should not assume too much beyond basic linguistic notions (even many of these are not universally agreed to!)

- You want to show that you can think — and have thought — about the topic.
  - Therefore do **not** simply summarise what someone else has said; show that you are a critical reader, and that you can put the ideas together in different words, and in a different way.
  - Don't just agree with everything you read, but try and find weaknesses in the arguments, experiments, or whatever.
  - Does the evidence that the writer produces actually argue for their thesis?
  - How convincing do you find their story?

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5. Referencing

- Standard means of reference — use the Harvard system; do not use footnotes for references (as in history). The main features of the Harvard system of reference:

  - References in the text take the form Bloggs (1934:56); generally it is a good idea to give a page number, unless the point is a general one, relevant to the entire article
  - Put this in brackets in contexts such as: *according to construction grammar, morphemes are also constructions (Goldberg 1995:23)* (Note that in the case of quoting just 2 or 3 words one need not necessarily indicate that it is a quote.)
  - Don't put brackets around the author's name when the reference is incorporated in your text. Instead, put just the year and page numbers in brackets, as in *according to Malinowski (1923:327), grammatical rules are not there just for the sake of being there*

- In the list of references at the end of the article, which contains only works actually cited in your paper, give the sources of your information in the following forms:

  - Books:

    Peile, Anthony Rex. 1997. *Body and soul: an Aboriginal view.* Perth: Hesperian Press.

  - Articles in journals:

    Fraser, Bruce. 1988. Motor oil is motor oil: an account of English nominal tautologies. *Journal of Pragmatics* 12. 215-220.

  - Articles in edited books:

    Hale, Kenneth. 1994. Core structures and adjunctions in Warlpiri syntax. In Corver, Norbert & van Riemsdijk, Henk (eds.), *Studies on scrambling: movement and non-movement approaches to free word-order phenomena*. Berlin and New York: Mouton de Gruyter. 185-219.

- If your information comes from a website, then you should provide the web address, as well as the author and title of the document. Also indicate the last date on which you visited the site (this information is important, since the contents of websites can change drastically and rapidly, and may even disappear over night. It is preferable to cite a web address in a mono-spaced font such as Courier. For example:

  Nash, David. 1992. Warlmanpa language and country. Unpublished MS, ANU. http://www.anu.edu.au/linguistics/nash/papers/lgshift.pdf. (Accessed 33/13/1313)

Note that reference styles differ from journal to journal, from book to book. The above is just one way of doing it. It is fine to use another style, provided you are consistent.

☞ If you are not systematic in recording reference details in your essay from the very beginning, you are asking for problems later on in the final stages of your work. The best thing to do is to use a referencing program such as *Endnote*, and enter the bibliographical information into that. Then you input the required reference in the relevant place in your text, together with the page number (it will then look like "[Crowley, 2001 #2662]:245"). When you have finished the paper, you simply generate it from within Endnote, which creates a bibliography at the end of your paper, and replaces the above in text-reference by "Crowley 2001:245".

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6. Other considerations

- **Plagiarism**. This is an important and difficult problem. Don't quote word for word (or almost word for word, or by simply modifying words and sentence structure of a source) from someone else's writing without acknowledging it (give the page reference, as well as the standard details of the publication — see below). Usually quotes are fairly easy to tell because of different styles. (Don't quote from other students' essays, either!)

- **Notes**. Use footnotes only for elaborating or explanatory comments not important enough to go in the main text, that would break up the flow. (Don't use footnotes for references to literature as is done in history — see §5 above.)

  - You can also use endnotes, but these can be annoying for readers if they have to find the place of the note in a long text — it is much easier to just look at the foot of the page. (You have probably been annoyed by having to do this in some books.)

- **Writing to length**. It is very difficult to write to a specified length, even for experienced writers. Nevertheless, you will probably have length restrictions on your essay that will need to be followed — handing in 5 pages or 25 pages when 12-15 is asked for is not generally accepted.

  - My advice is not to take the length restrictions too seriously when composing your first draft. Write it to the length you feel comfortable with.
  - After you have written the first draft, check it against the required size, and adjust accordingly, either by reducing or expanding.

    - Some care is required in reducing or expanding — don't add irrelevancies in expanding just to make up the required number of pages (this will be obvious to the reader, who is unlikely to view if favourably!), and when reducing, be careful to remove all references to the deleted material.

- **Cross-referencing**. It is often useful to make a cross-reference to some other place in your text (like a hyperlink in a web document, except that the reader has to find the place). For instance, if you discuss the body-part counting system of the Oksapmin in page 10 or section 2.4 of your paper, and you mention it in your introduction (but don't want to discuss it in detail there), it may be useful to make a reference to the relevant page or section in the introductory text. Usually this is done in the form of "see p. 10" or "see §2.4".

  - If you mention somewhere a concept or idea that is discussed in detail elsewhere in the paper, then it may be worth making a cross-reference to that notion. Or if something you mention at a particular point is likely to raise questions in the reader's mind, cross-referencing to a place where you deal with those questions is called for.

- Other places where cross-referencing is standard include to figures, tables, and numbered linguistic examples. In most cases there should be a reference in your text to such items (i.e. you don't just give a figure, but refer to it). It is preferable to refer to the table, figure or example number rather than use expressions like "see the table below" — you might shift text around so that it ends up above the cross-reference.
- It is recommended that you use the cross-referencing facility of your word processing program **right from the beginning**. Any decent word processing package allows you to make cross references to pages, table numbers, figure numbers, example numbers, or whatever.

  - If you don't use this facility (along with automatic numbering of tables, figures, examples, etc.), you are asking for extra work — probably you will have forgotten the point you wanted to make the reference to, or its number has changed.
  - If you don't know how to use either cross-referencing or automatic numbering in your word processing package, it is time to find out how. Read the manual!

- **Layout**. Your essay will be read by someone, so give some consideration to their eyes — use 12 point font, preferably Times, with reasonable space between the lines (1½ to double space is recommended).

- **Academic style**. See also Chapter 25 of Wray, Trott & Bloomer 1998 for information on academic English.

- **Style guides**. Most international academic journals have their own style guides, giving information on their own preferred styles, usually some relatively minor variant of the above. As an example, you might like to look at the style guide for *Linguistic Typology*.

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References

Wray, Alison, Trott, Kate & Bloomer, Aileen. 1998. *Projects in linguistics: a practical guide to researching language*. London: Arnold.

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